

>> posture stretch

We all want healthy posture. Although we live in an imperfect world, near perfect posture can be achieved by methodically balancing our body against gravity's pull. Where the body leads, the mind goes. Improving posture will lift your outlook on life as well as giving you confidence and endurance against everyday stresses.

Stretching for healthy posture means fighting against the pull of gravity. If we do not work against gravity's pull, then the longer we live, the more bent and deformed we become. A typical gravitational pull creates a forward-jutting chin, a tight chest, and rounded shoulders. Continuing down the body, the abdomen becomes lax and the lower back becomes tighter. A domino effect continues on into the legs, shortening the front of the thighs and creating a loose area around the glutes. The end-result is an off-center line, with tight calves causing the body weight to fall back into the heels (see p.16). It's no wonder joints wear out before their time. We're all living longer, so our joints—which are a key factor in our quality of life—are important to us. The value of healthy posture cannot be stressed too much. Not only do we achieve a pleasing cosmetic effect by standing upright, we also increase our vitality, since standing well promotes optimal lung capacity, which provides more oxygen for the brain to function well.

The exercises

The Posture stretch sequence follows a muscle-balancing formula as well as reinforcing the neuro-developmental sequence—in other words, the basic movement patterns that get a baby from lying down to standing and walking. The Posture stretch sequence uses all the positions that babies must achieve on their journey to walking.

>> tips for posture stretch

- **Focus on the ultimate goal** of elongating your entire body in every exercise.
- **Notice how each exercise builds** toward firm, upright posture.
- **Modify when needed.** Be sensible and use extra padding under the knees if they are tender.
- **Enhance balance** by focusing your eyes on a fixed object or by holding onto furniture, if necessary.
- **In the final standing exercise,** focus first on stretching out and elongating your waist as you lengthen your ribs up and off the pelvis; locate your head weight over the center of gravity in the pelvic bowl.

Starting with exercises lying on the back, trunk control is developed which enables optimum control of the limbs. Pay special attention to the various parts of the front of the trunk in the Elongations. Notice how the “W’s” exercise straightens and elongates you, combating the typical fetal curling position many adopt when